

Images of the Desert — Wadi and En Gedi

PRIMARY TEXTS: READ OR MEDITATE ON A POWERFUL PASSAGE

Your sandals are dusty, sweat drips from your brow, as you walk under the fiercely hot sun.

How will you make it? How *far* will you make it? You've rested your head under the shade of a rotem bush, was it, today? Yesterday?

You follow the feet in front of you on rocky paths, sometimes barely able to see 200 yards ahead due to the curving chasms of the deep wadis. No rain has fallen here for quite some time, a tree lies dormant—not its time to thrive—so you carry on.

**... refuge
becomes a
distant
memory or
mirage.**

How long can a people, let alone one person, wander from place to place, before giving up entirely? There's been shade here and there, but this whole trusting the story thing is more easily and understandably questioned when refuge becomes a distant memory or mirage.

Yet there is a theme that weaves itself through all of the stories that highlight the time of God's people in the desert—community. From Abraham to Isaac to Jacob to Moses, there was a call from God to be people, one people, of God, meant to bless all others. A people who looked different with their radical hospitality and love and generosity and shared passion for justice. And let's not leave out the back-breaking bread kneading of Sarah or cistern climbing of Rebekah. Women who fed and brought water to those in the desert.

The call for community is strong throughout the Text. This doesn't make the desert moments unavoidable, but makes trekking through them possible, beautiful—transformative even—because of the call not only to seek shade, but to *be* it.

To be rest. To be a refuge, an oasis.

We are not meant to walk the desert alone—to be the lone wanderer in the wilderness.

**To be rest.
To be a refuge
and an oasis.**

There are others who walk before us, and after us, and as we've been discovering through these images of the desert, there's so much possibility once we've realized we're not alone. We find shade in the arms of others. We plant tamarisks without looking back to see how it will shape the deserts of those who come later, because we trust that the desert—the crucible that it is—has something around the next bend in the road.

What could that something be?

I remember that hike through the wadis, following the person before me, who followed the next, who followed the rabbi. Wondering how much farther I'd make it, I looked down at my dusty sandals, sweat dripping from my brow. Then, sudden shock as I looked up to find not more rocky terrain, but a small waterfall—a pool hidden in the heart of the heat of the desert.

An oasis. A refuge in the wilderness. En Gedi.

Perhaps this was the most powerful image I took home with me from my time in the desert. Thinking of those who had been an En Gedi to me. Who I had, or should, or COULD, be an En Gedi for. And how I could intentionality create a space where others could wander in, or out, to find the shalom and living water that they needed.

**It's about being
different from the
inside out.**

Our own wanderings through the wilderness may make us more familiar with the terrain, but not imperceptible to its curses, its toxic fruit, or heatstroke. Our communities, the ones we create refuge for and with along the way, make looking back at the bruises and lessons of the desert mean something more than just pain. And, as we walk in time and again, or watch those we love create their own pathways through, we can trust and hold to the hope that we left the desert a little bit better than we found it.

PRAYER

God, our Cornerstone,

*As we wander in the wilderness,
may we be a people of hope and peace
carrying your living water with us.
May we have the faith to trust,
take a deep breath, another step, and say,
"Let's see what the Lord provides around the next bend."*

*We bless You for the En Gedis we've found
along the paths of our own deserts.
May we be more like them, more like You,
Creating and becoming an oasis, a refuge—
not stuck in muddy waters or sinking sand—
but rooted, and built, upon you, our Cornerstone.
For you are our God.*

*May Your light continue to shine upon us.
Amen*

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 29

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

What might be important to meditate over from the images present in the mentioned passages and the journey of Exodus? What part of the Text, or image, may you want to just sit with?



COMMUNITY

How does your community seek to be and create En Gedi? How might you provide an oasis of living water, hope, shalom, for those needing it most? Who has been this for you?



DISCIPLESHIP

The image of En Gedi is also a beautiful image of discipleship. A relationship that provides growth and refuge. Who can you bring alongside you not just to bring rest to, but to bring teaching and hope into their life? To model "let's see what God has in store around the next bend"?



WRESTLING

What are you wrestling with? The deeper meanings of the wadi and En Gedi? How such images fit into our understanding of Israel's time in the desert? Remember, questions and wrestling are good! Especially in community.



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

We believe that **if we do our part in creating space for God, He will fill it.** What spiritual practices might you need to connect with God so you build your trust in what lies around the corner? How might the smallest practice fill you with more of Him and help you create and be an oasis for others? What practice could you refine, pick up again, or challenge yourself to try for the first time? If you create the space—He will fill it.

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

We believe young adults are shaping the future, and they need to experience trusting the journey in the desert as well as the refuge in En Gedi along the way—and this can happen through people like you! **They need to see what it looks like to follow God in the wilderness, to trust the Story, and to do so for others as well.** Be on the lookout for those young people who may cross your path that you can be an En Gedi to.

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

Imagine how our world, our theology of work, might be different if we lived each moment not just trying to survive the desert, but looking out for others along the way? To walk, and work, in hope and trust? Living in intimacy with God is how you can become a refuge even as you pursue your 9–5, and how that changes you and the people you meet. Does your physical work put you in a position help others through their deserts? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can make an impact. **You are doing sacred work and can make it through the desert, helping others on the journey as well.**